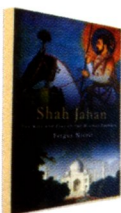


The Emperor of ROMANCE

This lucid portrait of the most complex Mughal brings out his triumphs and tragedy



**SHAH JAHAN:
THE RISE AND
FALL OF THE
MUGHAL EMPEROR**

by FERGUS NICOLL

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| By Dilip Bobb |

There's one thing about history: it's never past or permanent. Literary archaeologists are forever bringing a new perspective or new research to a historical subject. The new trend seems to be the number of British writers who are rediscovering Mughal India. It started with William Dalrymple's *Last Mughal* and now we have BBC journalist Fergus Nicoll who exhumes Shah Jahan, dusts him off and reassesses his place in history. It's a wise choice. Of all the great Mughals, only he left behind a permanent reminder of his place in history, the world's grandest monument to love, the ethereal Taj Mahal, a building Tagore called the "teardrop on the cheek of eternity". Indeed, much of Shah Jahan's turbulent life has been overshadowed by the voluminous accounts of his architectural genius, most notably the tribute to his favourite wife, Mumtaz Mahal.

His life and times deserve closer scrutiny for a variety of reasons. Although historians have literally done him to death, newshounds

like Nicoll combine intensive research with writing skills to add something unique. As he reminds us, the Mughal court was where violent politics, internecine conflict, bureaucratic intrigue and exalted art all coexisted under the same canopied roof. Nothing illustrated that better than the reign of Shah Jahan (1628-1658).

Outstanding general, rebel prince, patron of

the arts, his reign was a complex and conflicting tale of romance and betrayal, enlightened reforms and moral depravity. Nicoll uses contemporary documents, accounts of court biographers, Shah Jahan's own edicts and correspondence to trace the rise of Prince Khurram, later Shah Jahan, to his final years of solitary confinement, betrayed by his favourite son, Aurangzeb. History has been kinder to him than his life would suggest and Nicoll attempts to set the record straight. He traces Mumtaz Mahal's aristocratic upbringing and influential position within the polygamous harem where she became Shah Jahan's closest political adviser. Nicoll also quantifies the extent of Shah Jahan's staggering wealth, a treasury that dwarfed that of any European monarch and gave him the licence to spend on vanity projects such as the elaborate Peacock Throne.

In many ways, Shah Jahan's life paralleled his fathers. Jehangir started the trend of rebelling against his father, Akbar, and Shah Jahan followed suit. Like his father, a woman played a major role in his life and accomplishments. Jehangir's favourite wife, Nur Jehan wielded unprecedented influence. Indeed, it was her decision to engineer the marriage of her niece, Lady Arjumand, with her stepson Prince Khurram, knowing Jehangir's favourite son would one day be king. Arjumand entered South Asia's most powerful family with a new name, Mumtaz Mahal. All this is powerful stuff, as history goes, and Nicoll knits it all together with skill and dedication. He is very much a Mughal history buff: many of the miniatures used in this book as illustrations are from his personal collection.

Shah Jahan shifted the capital to Delhi, or Shahjanabad, where he constructed the Red Fort and Jama Masjid, but it was in Agra that Shah Jahan would spend eight of his last years as a prisoner of his son, Aurangzeb, squinting at the distant silhouette of the Taj Mahal, little knowing that one day it would be declared the Seventh Wonder of the World. Nicoll does devote a fair share of his book to the concept, design and building of the Taj but only in the context of the larger portrait, a fascinating reappraisal of one of history's most complex kings.

